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FACES

He digs dinosaurs

By MARTHA LIEBRI
Today Editor

Most little boys go through a dinosaur phase. Some of them never grow out of it. "I saw my first dinosaur when I was four—and I've loved 'em ever since," said Dr. Wann Langston Jr., "and most paleontologists will tell you the same story."

Paleontologists are experts on fossil remains (including dinosaurs) and Langston, a Ph.D. at the University of Texas at Austin, is currently reconstructing the remains of an 80-foot dipodocus which will be star attraction at the Museum of Natural Science in Houston. Langston is lecturer in the Department of Geological Sciences and director of Vertebrate Paleontology Laboratory at UT. The drives to Houston regularly to work on the dipodocus, and has for the last couple of years.

He manages to get out into the field, usually the fossil-rich Big Bend area about every three or four years, he says, but students of his make regular forays there, and one recently uncovered the giant pterodactyl, which to date is the largest flying reptile fossil ever discovered. Texas made headlines with its "big bird" with its 50-foot wingspan, and Langston and his staff have it reconstructed and on display now at the Texas Memorial Museum at UT.

Almost all detailed dinosaur reconstructions include a good proportion of man-made bones molded out of plastic, and Langston says it gets a rise out of him when some museum visitor watching him work on dipodocus mutters, "I hear they're doing it out of plastic."

"There has never been a complete set of fossil bones reconstructed of a creature like this, though there are some that are more complete than ours," he says.

The Houston dipodocus is about half "real" and the other half has been built by Langston and his aide, John Barber. Barber currently is working on the dipodocus project but his chosen field is sculpture and he has works for sale in several Houston galleries.

Langston begins by carving a particular bone out of plaster. Then a mold is made, and a combination of strong light liquid plastic poured in. The result, a really fossil-looking piece ready to fit in wherever a part is missing. The front legs, and one back leg, the pelvis and most of the neck are real. Langston is painting the plastic pieces a solid dark brown so they can be distinguished from the unpainted fossil bones.

Houston's dipodocus pieces were bought for \$15,000 several years ago from a museum which had been storing them for more than 70 years. They were originally found around 1862 by an expedition funded

by Andrew Carnegie (who was also a dinosaur fan). He wanted fossils for his Carnegie Museum, but his parties found several better specimens so they just stored the smaller one. Around 1944 it was traded to the Cleveland Museum but before they got it, they found their own and better specimens so dipodocus went back into storage. Most of this country's dinosaur reconstruction went on around World War I, Langston said, and there have been only two new reconstructions in recent years.

Because of the rising costs of launching expeditions, Langston says it is becoming less likely such projects will be undertaken. He recently estimated it would have cost \$300,000 to dig up and restore a dipodocus like the one he is doing for Houston.

One of the problems is people. "It's becoming more difficult to find fossils. People have more time and better access to places like the Badlands. And they go out and find fossils 'weathered out' in rocks, and they pick them up or destroy them."

Despite it's superlative, Texas is not a terrific place for paleontologists to search, he says. Wyoming and Colorado have yielded good specimens. The paleontologist's dream location though is the Gobi Desert in central Asia. And, Langston says, with something akin to a faraway gleam in his eye, "Tanzania, 'where the bones come right out of the floor of the jungle.'"

The dinosaur era began 275 million years ago and ended 64 million years ago, Langston says, and while fossils have always been around, man did not begin to recognize and salvage them until the 1850s, he said, mainly because of strong religious beliefs which did not allow for evolutionary thoughts. When someone began to recognize fossils as bones, and began digging for more, they came up with names. The name dinosaur was coined in the 1850s, Langston says.

A good deal of what is "known" about dinosaurs is conjecture. Dipodocus, about twice the size of the African elephant, was so heavy that scientists theorize he spent most of his time in the water. They surmise he was a vegetarian, and that this particular one was chewed on at one time or another by some other creature—his bones bear slash marks.

Langston and Barber are finishing placement of neck vertebrae this week and expect dipodocus to be ready for its coming-out party in two months.

Then the scaffolding will come down and there will be at least one glittery party to celebrate. And Dr. Langston will return to UT, content his dipodocus will stand at least another 100 years.



Wann Langston Jr., left, and his aide John Barber
— Post photo by Bill Thompson

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